

KELSEY PUKELIS

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HARVARD
UNIVERSITY

EDUCATION

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2025 (expected)

Ph.D. in Public Policy (Economics Track)

Fields: Public Economics, Labor Economics

Research Interests: Social Safety Net Policy, U.S. Nutrition Assistance Policy

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL 2017

B.A. in Economics, Mathematics, Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences (triple major)

Interdisciplinary Honors in Economics & Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences

Cum Laude; Phi Beta Kappa

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Scholar in Inequality, Harvard University 2021 – 2025

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship 2021 – 2024

Harvard Graduate Prize Fellowship 2019 – 2021

RESEARCH GRANTS

Institute for Quantitative Social Science Graduate Student Research Grant, Harvard University 2024

Malcolm Wiener Center for Social Policy Qualitative Research Grant, Harvard University 2024

Stone Research Grant, James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Program in Wealth Distribution,
Inequality & Social Policy, Harvard University 2023

Division of Social Sciences Fund (with Michael Holcomb), Harvard University 2022

Mind Brain Behavior Graduate Student Award (with Alice Heath), Harvard University 2021

Harvard Center for American Political Studies Graduate Seed Grant (with Alice Heath) 2021

PUBLICATION

“Employed in a SNAP? The Impact of Work Requirements on Program Participation and Labor Supply” (with Colin Gray, Adam Leive, Elena Prager, and Mary Zaki)

American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, 2023, 15(1): 306-341.

Work requirements are common in US safety net programs. Evidence remains limited, however, on the extent to which work requirements increase economic self-sufficiency or screen out vulnerable individuals. Using linked administrative data on food stamps (SNAP) and earnings with a regression discontinuity design, we find robust evidence that work requirements increase program exits by 23 percentage points (64 percent) among incumbent participants. Overall program participation among adults who are subject to work requirements is reduced by 53 percent. Homeless adults are disproportionately screened out. We find no effects on employment and suggestive evidence of increased earnings in some specifications.

WORKING PAPERS

“SNAP Policies and Enrollment following the COVID-19 Pandemic”

Since the COVID-19 pandemic, the national budget of the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) doubled, its caseload increased by 10 percent, and its application denial rate increased by nearly 50 percent. This paper investigates the factors behind these enrollment changes, including economic conditions and policy changes. I compile a new dataset on state policy waivers during the COVID-19 public health emergency, including flexibilities in application and recertification procedures and increases in benefit amounts (Emergency Allotments). Then, I use state-level policy variation to understand the effects of each policy on caseloads. I find that emergency supplemental benefits and recertification waivers drove enrollment increases. Descriptive evidence suggests that application denial rates increased both because recertification waivers cut off the typical flow of approved applications from otherwise churning cases and because relatively higher income households were more likely to apply.

“Stigma and Social Safety Net Program Participation” (with Alice Heath & Michael Holcomb)

Stigma may impede participation in social safety net programs and impose utility costs on individuals already receiving benefits. We use a nationally representative survey with descriptive and experimental components to document five facts about stigma and participation in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP). First, many individuals hold stigma-related beliefs about SNAP participation, and grocery stores are a setting with high potential for stigma. Second, individuals who currently participate in SNAP and who have more close acquaintances who use SNAP have lower levels of stigma. Third, most respondents overestimate how much others would judge SNAP participation, with participants overestimating more than non-participants. In the experimental portion of the survey, we find that randomized interventions have heterogeneous effects: they increase stigma among Republicans and current SNAP participants and decrease stigma among non-participants and Democrats. Finally, one intervention that addresses a common reciprocity concern increases interest in take-up among eligible non-participants but decreases support for SNAP spending across the whole sample. Together, these findings suggest the importance of stigma and social norms for influencing take-up of a large, targeted transfer program.

“The Impacts of Online Grocery Shopping with SNAP”

Many anti-poverty programs are in-kind, and adoption of new technology can affect how vendors deliver benefits to low-income participants. This project investigates how the availability of online grocery purchasing with Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) benefits impacts food retailer markets and program enrollment. I find that, by March 2023, 9 percent of all SNAP-authorized stores offered online purchasing, compared to 53 percent of supermarkets and superstores. Then, I use geographic variation in online purchasing availability to estimate impacts on program enrollment using a difference-in-differences design. Analyses suggest that the ability to shop online has null to small effects on county-level SNAP enrollment. This project describes a drastic change in the delivery of nutrition assistance programs and has implications for other in-kind benefit programs.

RESEARCH PAPERS IN PROGRESS

“Dynamic Enrollment in Transfer Programs: Evidence from Disaster SNAP” (with Laura Blount Carper)

“SNAP Benefit Changes and Household Grocery Purchases”

“Automatic Enrollment in Transfer Programs” (with Claire Leroy)

“The Health Impacts of SNAP Work Requirements” (with Bradley Katcher)

POLICY WRITING

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Establishing the Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer Program and Rural Non-Congregate Option in the Summer Meal Programs” (FNS-2023-0029). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), August 27, 2024.

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Program Purpose and Work Requirement Provisions of the Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023” (FNS-2023-0058). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), June 14, 2024.

Public comment to the U.S. Food and Nutrition Service’s Proposed Rule: “Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children: Online Ordering and Transactions and Food Delivery Revisions to Meet the Needs of a Modern, Data-Driven Program” (FNS-2022-0015-0001). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), May 26, 2023.

“SNAP work requirements don’t actually get more people working — but they do drastically limit the availability of food aid.” *The Conversation*, April 2023.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“SNAP Benefit Changes and Household Grocery Purchases”	November 2024 (planned)
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management Research Conference, National Harbor, MD	
“Benefit Changes in SNAP and Household Grocery Purchases”	November 2024 (planned)
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting, Washington, DC	
“The Impacts of Online Grocery Purchasing on SNAP Households”	July 2023
Agriculture & Applied Economics Association Annual Conference, Washington, DC	
“SNAP Application Policies and Enrollment during the COVID-19 Pandemic”	July 2022
Western Economic Association International Annual Conference, Portland, OR	

TEACHING

Harvard Kennedy School , Cambridge, MA	Spring 2023
<i>Quantitative Analysis and Empirical Methods II</i> (Master of Public Policy course)	
Teaching Fellow for Michela Carlana, Benjamin Schneer & Teddy Svoronos	
Harvard Kennedy School , Cambridge, MA	Spring 2022
<i>Resources, Incentives, and Choices II: Analysis of Public Policy</i> (Master of Public Policy course)	
Teaching Fellow for Mark Shepard	
University of Virginia , Charlottesville, VA	Fall 2018
<i>Advanced Topics in Impact Evaluation</i> (Master of Public Policy course)	
Teaching Assistant for Sally Hudson	

MENTORING

Invited Panel Speaker , Northwestern University’s Womxn in Economics Student Group	Fall 2023
Mentor , Harvard Undergraduates for Inclusion in Economics	2022
Mentor , MIT / Harvard Economics Application Assistance and Mentoring Program	2021 – 2022
Peer Mentor , Harvard Public Policy PhD Program	2020 – 2022
Classroom & Language Consultant , University of Virginia	2018 – 2019

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Referee, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*

Referee, *Agriculture & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting*

Student-Faculty Engagement Co-Chair, Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association 2022 – 2023

Social Committee Co-Chair, Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association 2021 – 2022

Student Organizer, Harvard Econometrics Reading Group 2020

AFFILIATIONS

Social Economics Lab, Harvard University, Affiliate

Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, Affiliate

Mosaic Economic Project, Progressive Policy Institute, Alumna

American Economic Association, Member

Agricultural & Applied Economics Association, Member

ADDITIONAL RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Microsoft Research New England, Cambridge, MA Summer 2020

Research Intern with Eleanor Dillon

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA 2017 – 2019

Frank Batten School of Leadership & Public Policy

Research Specialist Intermediate to Jennifer Doleac, Sally Hudson, and Adam Leive

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL 2014 – 2017

Two-Generation Educational Research Team, Institute for Policy Research

Research Assistant to Lindsay Chase-Lansdale and Teresa Sommer

SKILLS

Computer Proficient in Stata, R, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Git/GitHub, Microsoft Office

Experience with Python, HTML, BASH, ArcGIS, Matlab

Language English (native), Spanish (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (basic)

REFERENCES

Professor Marcella Alsan
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Professor Jeffrey Liebman
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